

Green Chevron

Chevron has just installed some 7,700 solar panels at a site in California to conduct tests

Fishing for fog?

People in Lima, Peru are using fishing nets to catch fog as a method to combat the water shortage



Green wheels

Chetan Maini is one of those rare people who get to live their dreams. As a young boy growing up in Bangalore, cars defined his world. At 39, Maini is setting automotive benchmarks for the world to follow

As told to Shreyasi Singh
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I was always putting things together. It was something I loved doing. Maybe the practice of taking things apart helped. My parents tell me even today that when I was very young, I broke everything, and when I got older, I fixed everything.

My love for motors began early. I started out by making remote-controlled cars and planes. In my teens, I was building motorised go-carts. Since specialised components were hard to come by in India, I would ask my dad's friends to buy spare parts when they travelled abroad. By 11, my

bedroom was too small for my hobby. I remember spending my weekends and holidays looking for electronic parts and designing motor mechanisms. School science fairs were a big deal for me.

Every boy loves his cars. But, my parents really nurtured that interest. My father ran a small electronics company then. When I wanted to build a radio in class four, he sent over one of his employees, an electrical engineer, to help me with it. In class six, I learnt how to model planes with the help of my uncle, a navigation instructor with an airlines company, and one of his students who was an aero modeller. The family network fuelled me.

The Lamborghini Countach is something I grew up dreaming about. I drive two Reva cars now, and enjoy all cars, but I have always had a soft spot for the Countach.

I studied mechanical engineering at the University of Michigan, where I was a member of the solar car team. We won the GM Sun Race in USA in 1990. It was here that the idea of a cost-effective electric vehicle, for city driving, first struck me.

Dr Lon Bell, a friend's father and a technologist, was my early mentor. After winning the GM Sun Race, my solar-car buddies and I had started talking about a company in the electric vehicle